Supervision

The supervisor

The main supervisor must be a **Professor at the Faculty of Medicine at UNIGE.** It's important to note that the term "main supervisor" or "thesis director" doesn't necessarily imply that this person will have the most significant role in day-to-day supervision. Instead, their role is to take on the academic responsibility for the PhD supervision.

Regarding the role and responsibilities, the main supervisor's duties as outlined in the University's doctoral code include:

1. Providing mentorship throughout all stages of the PhD program, from course selection to research program completion.
2. Guiding the student in program planning and ensuring adherence to the planned schedule.
3. Supporting the development of the student's research proposal, advising on the literature review, dissertation writing, and reviewing drafts and final versions of the dissertation and publications.
4. Encouraging and advising on training activities, such as participating in scientific meetings, attending external courses, and conducting fieldwork.
5. Assisting in fund-seeking endeavors, where applicable.
6. Supporting the student's career development.
7. Creating time to openly and respectfully discuss the student's PhD progress.
8. Being the main person responsible for the PhD student in case of co-supervision.
9. Ensuring that the student is allocated an appropriate amount of time to focus on their thesis and that there is an equitable distribution of their time between assistant-related responsibilities, research, and thesis work.

In particular:

- The main supervisor, together with the PhD student, identifies the need for specific additional courses.
- The main supervisor, along with the PhD student, selects members for the thesis Doctoral Committee (more information on the doctoral committee can be found directly below).
- Before the predoctoral presentation and at the end of the first year, the main supervisor must arrange a progress report meeting with the student and the Doctoral Committee, producing a short-written report to be attached to the student's predoctoral report.
- The main supervisor or a designated member of the Doctoral Committee must attend the predoctoral presentation.
- The main supervisor must validate the student's dissertation and submit it, along with a written report, to the program Steering Committee.

Doctoral committee

The main supervisor, in collaboration with the PhD candidate, is responsible for identifying potential members for the Doctoral Committee. The composition of this committee must be approved by the Steering Committee. The Doctoral Committee typically comprises three to four members, with the main supervisor being a mandatory member. The selection criteria for the committee include:

1. The main supervisor, who should be a Professor and a member of the UNIGE Faculty of Medicine.
2. An expert or co-supervisor, holding a doctoral degree, affiliated with a Swiss or foreign university.
3. An expert, holding a doctoral degree, who is a member of a Swiss or foreign university but not a co-supervisor.
4. Optionally, an additional expert without specific academic background requirements may be designated.

The primary purpose of the Doctoral Committee is to ensure proper doctoral training, evaluate the progress of the research, and provide additional expertise. It also serves as a platform for open communication and potential mediation if needed. Specifically, the committee's role includes:

- Evaluating the student's scientific skills and the progress of the doctoral project, allowing the candidate to benefit from the expertise of at least one external expert.
- Providing a forum for the PhD candidate to express opinions in the absence of the thesis director.
- Allowing the thesis director to provide feedback in the student's absence.
- Providing oral recommendations.

Annual meetings with the Doctoral Committee are expected, and the student should meet with the committee at least once a year. After each meeting, the committee should prepare a concise progress report (maximum two pages) and submit it to the coordination team.

Student

The student bears essential responsibilities to ensure steady progress in their PhD journey, encompassing both coursework and research activities. The student's role commences by initiating enrollment at the university and being proactive in seeking advice when necessary. Throughout the thesis work, the student collaborates with the thesis director to align with jointly set objectives. The student's responsibilities are further outlined in the university's doctoral code.

The student's responsibilities include:

- Engaging in regular discussions with the thesis supervisor(s) regarding the progress, challenges faced, and other pertinent aspects of the work.
- Collaborating with the supervisor to determine the specific focus of the thesis based on achieved results.

- Staying updated about relevant training courses that contribute to meeting the objectives.
- Devoting the necessary effort and dedication to achieve the successful completion of the doctoral thesis.
- Providing regular progress reports on the research to the doctoral committee.
- Upholding ethical standards, including the principle of authenticity in the thesis and respecting the confidentiality of any applicable portions of the work.
- Adhering to the collective rules and norms of the research unit in which they are involved, contributing to a harmonious and supportive environment for all members.
- Meeting the payment deadlines for the semester fees.

In essence, the student plays a central role in driving their PhD progress while maintaining a strong commitment to academic excellence and ethical conduct throughout the research journey.

Supervision Agreement

Starting from PhD cohort 10 (September 2023), a supervision agreement will be required for all students and supervisors. This agreement serves the purpose to formalize essential aspects of collaboration between the student and the supervisor regarding the doctoral project. The PhD coordination team will provide the terms and conditions of the agreement to the PhD student.

The agreement will be binding for both the student and the supervisor throughout the entire duration of the PhD program. Once the student receives the agreement via email, they are expected to share the document with their supervisor for signature. Subsequently, the student must co-sign and date the agreement and return it to the doctoral program coordination team. This process ensures clarity and accountability in the supervisory relationship, promoting a successful and productive doctoral journey.

Guidelines and Regulations

As a PhD candidate, there are several guidelines and regulations that you must adhere to in order to ensure that both the doctoral program and your research align with the university's standards. These guidelines and regulations play a crucial role in maintaining the quality and integrity of the doctoral process and ensuring that your research meets the required academic standards.

Doctoral code

Since May 2022 the University of Geneva has adopted a doctoral code. These university-wide guidelines encompass a comprehensive set of general principles that define the philosophy, framework, and requirements essential for a successful PhD project. Moreover, they establish clear roles and responsibilities for all individuals engaged in doctoral training at the University of Geneva. These guidelines are available here: https://memento.unige.ch/en/rectorat/charte-du-doctorat

Regulatory framework

The regulatory framework of the doctoral program comprehensively details all the official requirements and regulations of the PhD program. The document, written in French, can be accessed through the following link: Regulatory Framework of the PhD Program in Global Health.

International double doctoral degree

While the majority of our students typically pursue single-track PhDs within our program, the University of Geneva does have specific regulations for joint doctorates. These regulations provide guidance on seeking permission for a joint doctorate at UNIGE, along with the conditions that apply to such collaborative doctoral programs. For more detailed information, please refer to the following link: https://memento.unige.ch/en/doc/0327

Ethical clearance before data gathering

All PhD students participating in the Global Health PhD program are bound by the university's ethical rules and regulations, which necessitate adherence to the prescribed guidelines. Any research project that is not medical but involves human participants (e.g., a questionnaire, observations or interviews), that could have an environmental impact (only concerns projects taking place in the field and outside the lab); or whose results could be of military, security or political interest, for example (i.e., research with multiple purposes), need to seek advice from CUREG (University Commission for Ethical Research in Geneva): https://cureg.unige.ch/en/

For research involving human beings (HRA), the relevant ethics commission is the Cantonal Commission for Ethics and Research (CCER). To gain ethical clearance for such research projects, detailed information and procedures can be found on the following webpage: https://www.unige.ch/researchdata/en/collect-organise/ethics-legal-obligations/.

The same counts for animal research carried out abroad. All guidance and information can be found here: https://memento.unige.ch/en/doc/0295

It is essential to acknowledge that ethical clearance may vary based on the country of data gathering. Therefore, it is advisable to consult the ethical guidelines applicable in the country of research and within your respective organization. Ensuring compliance with ethical standards is paramount in upholding the integrity and credibility of your research endeavors.

Others

An overview of additional guidelines that can be helpful, such as procedures for knowledge transfer and international collaboration guidelines can be found here:
https://memento.unige.ch/en/doc

Research requirements

Publishing scientific articles in peer-reviewed journals

PhD students are required to **publish two scientific articles** during their doctoral studies. These articles must be published (or fully accepted) in peer-reviewed scientific journals, with the student as the first author and the main supervisor as a co-author. Please ensure that all published material during your PhD curriculum appropriately credits the University of Geneva, specifically mentioning the University of Geneva among your affiliations.

It's important to note that the research papers should not be viewpoints, commentaries, editorials, or correspondence pieces. However, such publications can be included in the thesis, in addition to the two published research papers.

There are no specific requirements regarding the type of research papers accepted, as long as they are research papers. For example, a systematic review without primary data collection is acceptable, and a non-quantitative analysis, such as an anthropological study with case studies, is also fine if deemed appropriate within the context of the research.

Before submitting these manuscripts, they must be approved by all co-authors. The main supervisor is actively involved in the planning and review process of the article.

Journals, publication costs, UNIGE agreements

When choosing a journal for submission, it is crucial to consider several factors. One important consideration is the publication costs, known as article processing charges (APC). The University of Geneva has established agreements with certain publishers to reduce or fully cover these publication fees. To access the latest list of journals with such agreements, you can visit this link: University of Geneva - Agreements with Publishers. Many journals, that do not have agreements with the university still offer APC waivers or reductions for researchers from low- and middle-income countries.

Moreover, for those articles that have been accepted in a fully open access journal (i.e., gold open access) but that are not under an agreement, the University of Geneva can cover the full publication cost if it does not exceed 2'500.- CHF. Eligibility criteria and guidelines are fund here: https://www.unige.ch/biblio/en/openaccess/get-published/publication-fund/

Furthermore, SSPH+ owns and publishes two independent society journals, namely the International Journal of Public Health and Public Health Reviews. These journals utilize the systems and services provided by Frontiers.

It is essential to have thorough discussions with your supervisor regarding the choice of journal for submission. They can provide valuable guidance and insights. It is also important to discuss financing opportunities for your papers, ensuring clarity on any available financial support or funding options.

Mid-term Evaluation (pre-doctoral thesis and oral thesis presentation)

The predoctoral thesis oral presentation takes place during the Spring School of Global Health, typically occurring in the second year of the program. This presentation serves as a significant milestone before the completion of the doctoral thesis. During this event, the doctoral student presents their thesis project to the Steering Committee, with at least one member of the student's Doctoral Committee in attendance.

It is crucial to give careful consideration to this milestone, as it plays a pivotal role in the finalization of the doctoral thesis. One month prior to the predoctoral thesis presentation, the student is required to submit a 5- to 10-page summary of their project to the Steering Committee. Following the presentation, the Steering Committee provides their recommendations to both the Doctoral Committee and the student.

The pre-doctoral presentation will be evaluated as either a pass or fail. In the event of a fail, the student will be given a second opportunity to present their pre-doctoral thesis. The maximum time window for the second presentation is 1 year, although the steering committee and the PhD coordination team may propose a shorter timeframe to avoid delays in the doctoral program. It is crucial to highlight that failing the pre-doctoral presentation for a second time will lead to termination from the program.

Pre-doctoral report

The pre-doctoral report serves as a summary of the progress achieved in the first 3 semesters of the PhD program. It encompasses an overview of research progress, such as data collection, ethical committee approvals, literature review, and more. Additionally, it highlights the acquisition of ECTS credits and completion of relevant courses. The report should also identify any bottlenecks or challenges encountered. It is anticipated to be 5-10 pages long and should be submitted to the PhD coordination team via email, one month prior to the pre-doctoral presentation. The coordination team will subsequently share the report with the Steering Committee members who will be present during the respective presentations.

The outline for the pre-doctoral summary is as follows:

Title page:

- Name of the PhD student(s)
- Name(s) of the supervisor(s)
- Names of the members of the doctoral committee

Summary of the thesis plan (1-2 pages):

- **Context:** Provide an overview of the research background and its significance.
- **Hypotheses:** Clearly state the hypotheses to be addressed in the research.
- **Original research**: Describe the research activities undertaken to address the hypotheses.
- **Work achieved:** Summarize the progress made so far.
- **Remaining work:** Identify the tasks that still need to be completed.
- **Publication status:** Detail any thesis-related publications, including abstracts, conference contributions, or published papers. Include full manuscripts or published papers in the appendix.

Completing Your Doctoral Program

After successfully completing and having at least two scientific articles accepted or published, it is time to conclude your PhD program. In this section of the handbook, we outline the essential steps to finalize your PhD journey.

These steps include:

1. **Writing and finalizing your PhD manuscript:** Start by composing your PhD manuscript and seek feedback from your main supervisor. Once your supervisor approves the manuscript and believes you are prepared for the next phase, you can move forward.

2. **Final exam:** The final exam is a crucial milestone in obtaining your PhD. It involves a lecture-style presentation, as determined by your supervisor, where you present one of the methodology topics covered in your PhD at a master's level to your PhD jury. This exam serves as the first official step towards acquiring your PhD.

3. **Public PhD defense:** After successfully completing the final exam, you are ready for your public PhD defense. This defense entails presenting and defending your research findings and conclusions to the academic community. It is a significant event, marking the culmination of your research journey.

Please refer to the figure on the next page for a summarized overview of the necessary steps and responsibilities of each individual involved in the process.

	Doctoral student	Supervisor(s)	Thesis jury	Thesis jury president	PhD coordination
PhD manuscript submission					
Writing of PhD manuscript and sharing with supervisor					
Approving that the thesis manuscript is of sufficient quality and completeness to initiate the steps towards thesis defense. Check for potential plagiarism					
Forming the thesis jury					
Compose director's report (contains a proposed jury composition) on the PhD manuscript					
Send director's report along with thesis manuscript to the PhD coordination team who transfers it to the Dean's office					
Upon receival of jury approval by the Dean the supervisor shares the PhD manuscript with the thesis jury members and copies the PhD coordination team in the email					
Final exam					
Setting date for final exam once jury composition is validated and share details with PhD coordination team					
Book room or create zoom link for final exam					
Formulating final exam question					
Sharing final exam question with PhD student (7 days before final exam)					
Informing jury and PhD student about exam format					
Preparation of 20-minute didactic presentation					
Evaluating final exam					
PhD defense					
Setting date for thesis defense					
Book room or create zoom link for PhD defense					
Evaluation of PhD manuscript and write evaluation report					
Share evaluation report with jury president					
Gathering all jury reports and give approval for defense					
Preparation of 30-minute presentation					
Chairs the public PhD defense					
Compile and generate the final report. Share the report with all jury members for their review and approval					
Approve jury report					
Share jury report with PhD student and PhD coordination team after jury approval					
After PhD defense					
Adminsitrative process of grade and defense finalization					
Incorporate feedback from jury report					
Check final version of the PhD manuscript and gives green light to print it					
Print thesis					
Upload thesis to archive ouvertes					

Figure 2 – Overview of steps and responsibilities per individual in the final steps of the PhD. When multiple individuals are highlighted it's a collaborative process.

Timeline

The doctoral program has a timeframe of a minimum of 6 semesters (approximately 3 years) and a maximum of 10 semesters (approximately 5 years). After the supervisor and PhD student agree on the finalization and completion of the PhD, which includes the articles accepted or published under the PhD project, they aim to find a date for the final exam and the public defense.

The PhD student needs to do the final exam after having submitted the final PhD thesis and before the public defense. One week before the final exam, the PhD student receives the topic for the final exam. There needs to be at least 2 months between the submission of the final PhD thesis and the public PhD defense. Upon receipt of the PhD manuscript, the thesis jury is given a period of 30 days to evaluate and assess it.

The date for the final exam needs to suit the UNIGE members of the thesis jury. The date for the public defense needs to suit all members of the thesis jury, both external and internal.

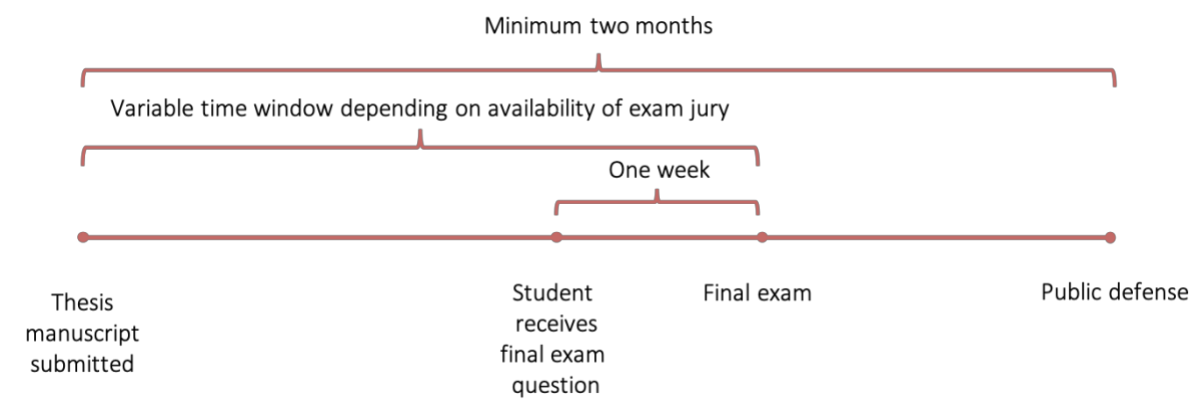

Figure 3 – The timeline for the final phase of the doctoral program consists of three key milestones: the submission of the thesis manuscript, the final exam, and the public defense. It is important to note that the duration between these milestones can vary.

Setting up the thesis jury and composition

The thesis jury consists of a minimum of 4 members, including:

a. The academic supervisor(s) of the doctoral student.
b. A designated member of the Steering Committee, who serves as the president of the jury.
c. A representative from the Dean's office.
d. One or two external experts who hold a doctoral degree.

The formation of the thesis jury occurs once the supervisor is informed of the completion and finalization of the doctoral program and is formed by the supervisor. It is beneficial to establish the jury and determine its composition as early as possible to facilitate the scheduling of a suitable date for all jury members.

Submitting the Thesis

Once the PhD student and supervisor(s) have reached an agreement on the completion of the PhD program, the student is required to submit the final PhD thesis to their supervisor. The supervisor, in turn, shares the manuscript with the thesis jury for evaluation. Furthermore, along with the manuscript, a report from the academic supervisor must be submitted. It is mandatory to submit the complete thesis at least **two months** prior to the scheduled date of the thesis defense. The proposition for the composition of the thesis jury is then presented to the Dean by the main supervisor. After the Dean's validation of the thesis jury composition, the manuscript is distributed to the respective members of the thesis jury for evaluation.

To ensure consistency, the student must adhere to a specific outline provided below.

Format & language

The thesis dissertation serves as a demonstration of the PhD candidate's expertise in managing crucial global health-related projects. The manuscript must be written in English or French (if so, all jury members must be able to read French). If written in English, an abstract of 1 to 2 pages in French should be included. The cover page should be in French. During the initial submission, the manuscript should be in Word document format (A4). Printing of the thesis is only allowed once it has been evaluated for plagiarism issues and has received a successful "imprimatur" status.

Manuscript based on articles:

If the candidate has published two scientific articles in peer-reviewed journals, with the candidate as the first author and the main supervisor as a co-author, the manuscript may follow a specific structure as outlined below. The publications should be incorporated within the manuscript accordingly.

1. Acknowledgments (optional)
2. List of publications, manuscripts in preparation, submitted manuscripts, oral communications produced during the study period which may or may not be directly related to the thesis topic
3. Abstract in English
4. Abstract in French (1-2 pages)
5. Outline
6. General introduction (8-10 pages)
   Must be more elaborate than the introductions in the published articles
7. Articles
   Methodological Contributions (1-2 pages)
   The methods must include a section detailing the role of the candidate in the thesis work (role in protocol elaboration, literature search, data collection and analysis, paper writing)
   Article 1
   Article 2
   …
8. Conclusions and perspectives (5-10 pages)
   Must be more elaborate than the conclusions found in published articles
9. Bibliography (Vancouver format)
10. Annexes (if applicable)

Monograph:
In the case that the candidate has produced a monograph, the structure detailed below must be followed:

1. Acknowledgments (optional)
2. List of publications, manuscripts in preparation, submitted manuscripts, oral communications related to the thesis
3. Abstract in English
4. Abstract in French (1-2 pages)
5. Outline
6. General introduction and research hypothesis
7. Material and methods
   The methods must include a section detailing the role of the candidate in the thesis work (role in protocol elaboration, literature search, data collection and analysis, paper writing)
8. Results
9. Discussion
10. Conclusion and perspective
11. Bibliography
12. Annexes: publications from the candidate, if any

Book chapter:
If the candidate has authored a book chapter as the first author, co-signed by the main supervisor, it can be incorporated into the thesis manuscript. This allows for the inclusion of the book chapter as part of the overall thesis document.

Responsibilities

Student:
- Writes the PhD manuscript.
- Submits the completed PhD manuscript to the supervisor.

Supervisor:
- Takes full responsibility of approving that the thesis manuscript is of sufficient quality and completeness to initiate the steps towards thesis defense. Check for potential plagiarism must have been done by the supervisor.
- Sends the director's report (contains a proposed jury composition) along with the thesis manuscript to the PhD coordination team who transfers it to the Dean's office.
- Awaits approval from Dean's office of jury composition.
- Upon receival of jury approval the supervisor shares the thesis manuscript with the thesis jury members and copies the PhD coordination team in the email. The supervisor should be aware that sharing the thesis manuscript should be done at least 30 days before the public defense date.

Thesis evaluation
Upon receiving the manuscript, the thesis jury is granted a period of 30 days to evaluate it. At the conclusion of this timeframe, the president of the thesis jury is responsible for preparing

an evaluation report **based on the reports of the individual jury members**. The report explicitly indicates whether the candidate has qualified for the thesis defense. The report will be forwarded to the Dean and steering committee by the coordinating team.

If the manuscript does not meet the necessary qualifications for progression, it will be regarded as the candidate's first failure. In the written report, the jury must specify the modifications required to be made by the candidate. It is important to note that a second failure is considered final and conclusive.

Final Exam

The final exam is conducted towards the completion of the doctoral program. It is conducted as a final step to assess the candidate's readiness to obtain their doctoral degree. The final exam is a 20-minute oral presentation and assessment that evaluates the candidate's knowledge, didactic skills, and ability to communicate their research effectively. The final exam needs to be successfully passed (minimum grade of 4 out of 6) to continue preparations towards the public defense.

The Exam Jury

- The Exam Jury is composed of the academic supervisor, a member of the program Steering Committee, and a member from the Dean's office.
- The exam jury consists of the same members as the defense jury, with the exception that the external expert is not included in the exam jury.
- The member of the Steering Committee chairs the exam session.

Final Exam Format

The final exam for the doctoral program involves giving a 20-minute presentation. The supervisor will decide on the topic one week before the exam, giving the student enough time to prepare. It's important to make sure the presentation is understandable to a master's level audience, even if they don't know much about the specific research method or theme. Using clear language, informative slides, and practical examples will help make the topic easier to grasp. Remember to focus solely on delivering a well-prepared lecture on the assigned topic and avoid talking about personal research or achievements, as this presentation is separate from the thesis defense.

The final exam format for the doctoral program includes the following key elements:

Exam Preparation

- The final exam is based on the thesis manuscript.
- The candidate receives the exam question from the supervisor/exam jury one week before the presentation to allow time for preparation.